

BRITISH NAVAL OFFICERS' UNIFORM

The British Royal Navy's officer class in the 18th and early 19th centuries was primarily made up of men as young as 12 to 14 years of age who came from respectable backgrounds. The Navy offered a tempting career during wartime, despite the hazards of life at sea. In addition to opportunities for promotion, there was the chance to become rich from the prize money paid by the Admiralty to those officers and crew who took possession of enemy ships. These young recruits initially learned how to navigate and operate a warship as midshipmen. They would hope for promotion to lieutenant after around six years, and for command of their own ship by the age of 21. Uniforms for officers, predominantly in white and navy blue, were first issued in 1748, and a new pattern was introduced in 1774.



▲ CAPTAIN'S HAT

Date c.1750

Origin England

Material "Half-beaver" felt

A captain would usually carry his hat under his arm so that his wig was not displaced. The material was "half-beaver" – a type of felt with beaver hair added to increase its firmness. The hat was then lined with silver lace.

► MIDSHIPMAN'S FROCK COAT

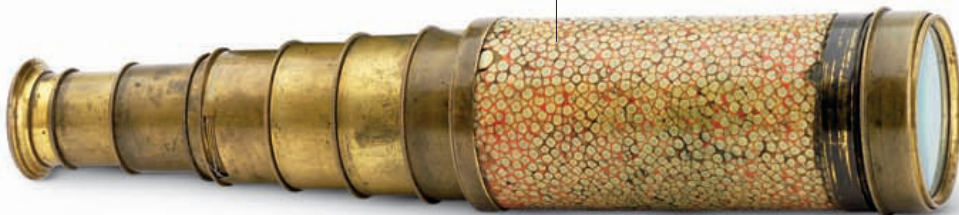
Date 1748

Origin England

Material Wool, velvet

The "mariner's cuff" in white with a three-point blue section was widely fashionable beyond the Royal Navy, appearing in suits and riding clothes as well. The wool collar is lined with white velvet.

Red-dyed rayskin covering the barrel



▲ OFFICER'S TELESCOPE

Date c.1800

Origin England

Material Glass, brass, rayskin, sharkskin

An officer used a hand-held telescope to identify approaching vessels, view flag signals, and help him gauge possible navigational hazards. This telescope had seven draw tubes, and the eyepiece cover, draw tubes, and fittings were made of brass. It could be retracted and fitted into a sharkskin case.

Mariner's cuff



▲ MIDSHIPMAN'S DIRK

Date c.1800

Origin England

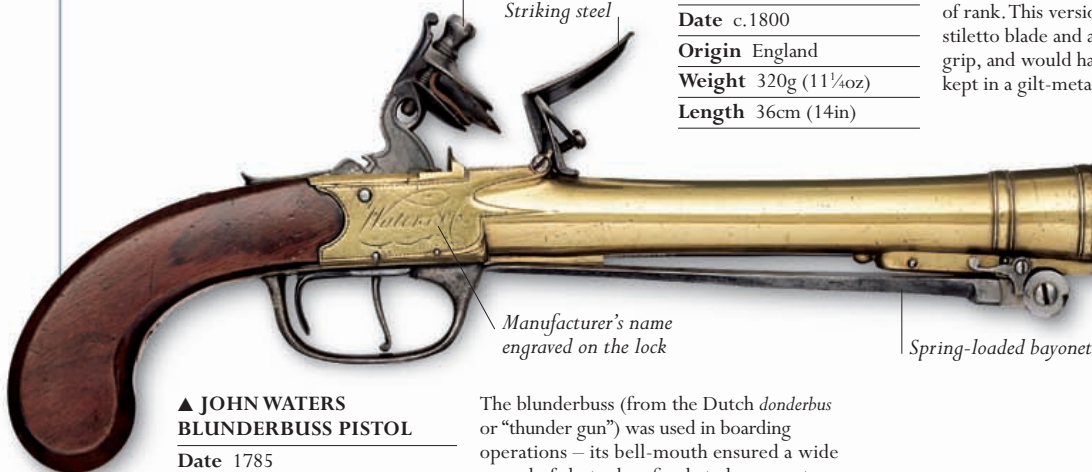
Weight 320g (11¼oz)

Length 36cm (14in)

Midshipmen carried a short sword called a dirk as a mark of rank. This version has a stiletto blade and an ivory grip, and would have been kept in a gilt-metal sheaf.

Jaw clamp screw

Striking steel



▲ JOHN WATERS BLUNDERBUSS PISTOL

Date 1785

Origin England

Weight 950g (33½oz)

Barrel 19cm (7½in)

Calibre 1in

The blunderbuss (from the Dutch *donderbus* or "thunder gun") was used in boarding operations – its bell-mouth ensured a wide spread of shot when fired at close quarters. This box-lock model was made by John Waters of Birmingham, who held the patent on the pistol bayonet. His name is legible on the rectangular box enclosing the lock mechanism.

Manufacturer's name engraved on the lock

Spring-loaded bayonet

